

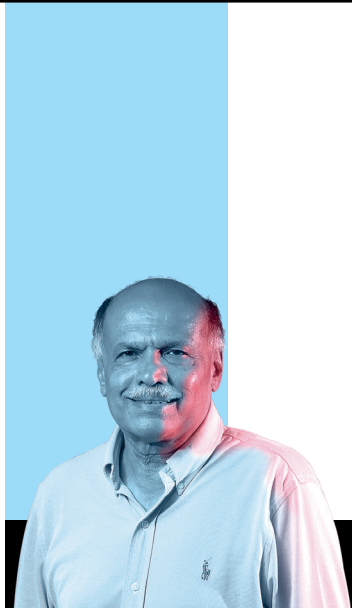
THE REFORMS THAT opened up the aviation sector in 1991 and ended the monopoly of Indian Airlines and Air India changed the sector when a slew of private sector airlines were given the licence to fly. Again, when the low-cost airlines took wings in 2003 they broke the cost barrier by penetrating deep into the rural hinterland.

Sadly, while all sectors have grown by leaps and bounds, Indian aviation has become 'the sick man of India'. Thanks to choking regulations, tough entry barriers for new entrants, high fuel prices abetted by high taxes, inefficient public sector airports paving the way for monopoly airports that are extortionist in the absence of robust competition and the lack of a long-term strategic policy, growth of aviation has again slumped. Multiple airports serve cities like New York, London, Paris and Washington DC. We need privatisation but not cartelisation. Airports must compete like airlines to keep prices under check and improve the quality of service. The HAL airport in Bengaluru and the old government airport in Hyderabad should never have been closed when new airports were allowed, to ensure competition. This must be borne in mind for the future.

Our bilateral and open sky policies need to be rethought boldly so that major metro air-

Vision 2047: Everyone Must Fly

While many sectors have grown by leaps and bounds, a measly 4 per cent of Indians travel by air. So, what ails the world's fastest-growing aviation market?



BY G.R. GOPINATH

ports can become mega transportation hubs like Dubai, Singapore and London. Our existing airports shouldn't be shy of competition.

The number of Indians who buy air tickets in a year is 140 million, which is a pre-Covid-19 figure. However, they are not 140 million different individuals. That number comprises repeat flyers of 35-40 million who form the bulk of the ticket buyers. Thus, the number translates to less than 4 per cent of the population who can afford air travel, placing India in terms of per capita consumption of air tickets alongside some poor African countries. Brazil, Malaysia, Indonesia and China are way ahead of India.

While on my way to the US for an aviation conference in 2002, at Luton airport—one of the five international airports serving the London Metropolitan area—I saw an advertisement that screamed the airport had flown 13 million passengers per annum. That hit me like lightning. All 40 airports in India flew as much then. On a flight of Southwest Airlines to Phoenix in the US, a heavily tattooed burly man in shorts and a vest sat next to me with his family at the back. I learnt he was